Tasking - Student Manual

Your Personal Task Management Guide for Zip Code Wilmington

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Introduction

Welcome to Tasking! This is your personal task management system designed specifically for Zip Code Wilmington students. Tasking helps you stay organized, track your progress, and manage the many assignments, projects, and professional development activities you'll encounter during your journey.

What is Tasking?

Tasking is a **multi-tenant web application** built specifically for students and instructors. It provides:

- **Personal Task Management**: Create and track your own tasks
- **Instructor Assignments**: Receive and manage tasks assigned by instructors
- **Visual Organization**: Use a Kanban board to see your work at a glance
- **Progress Tracking**: Monitor your completion status and stay on schedule
- **Cohort Integration**: Organized by your cohort (e.g., Java11.2, Data6.2)

Why Use Tasking?

During your time at Zip Code Wilmington, you'll juggle: - Individual programming labs - Group programming projects - Reading assignments - Documentation tasks - Resume building - Professional development activities - Demo presentations - Research and design work

Tasking helps you **see everything in one place** and **stay in control** of your learning journey.

Getting Started

Accessing Tasking

1. **Open your web browser** and navigate to the Tasking application URL provided by your instructor

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2. **Log in** with your assigned username and password
3. Your username is typically first initial, last name (or your assigned ID)
4. Your initial password will be provided by your instructor
5. **Dashboard**: After logging in, you'll see your personal Kanban board

First-Time Setup

When you first log in: 1. Review any tasks already assigned to you by instructors 2. Familiarize yourself with the four status columns (explained below) 3. Consider creating a few personal tasks to get comfortable with the system

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Understanding Kanban Boards

What is a Kanban Board?

A **Kanban board** is a visual workflow management tool that originated in Japanese manufacturing and is now widely used in software development and personal productivity. The word "kanban" (看板) means "visual signal" or "card" in Japanese.

Why Kanban Works

Kanban boards help you: - **Visualize your work**: See all your tasks at once - **Limit work in progress**: Focus on completing tasks before starting new ones - **Improve flow**: Move tasks smoothly from start to completion - **Identify bottlenecks**: Spot where work is getting stuck - **Track progress**: See how much you've accomplished

The Four Columns in Tasking

Your Tasking board has **four status columns**:

1. Pending (To Do)

- Tasks you haven't started yet
- Newly assigned tasks appear here
- This is your backlog of work

When to use: This is where tasks start. Don't let this column get too overwhelming—prioritize what's most important. You can drag the cards to order them in priority.

2. In Progress (Doing)

- Tasks you're actively working on
- Limited to what you can realistically handle at once

When to use: Move a task here when you actually start working on it. Try to limit how many tasks are "in progress" at once—focus is key!

3. Blocked (Stuck)

- Tasks that are stopped due to dependencies or issues
- Need help from instructors, teammates, or external factors

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When to use: If you can't proceed because you're waiting for something (feedback, help, access to resources), move it here so instructors can see you need assistance.

4. Completed (Done)

- Tasks you've finished
- Your record of accomplishment

When to use: Celebrate! Move tasks here when they're fully complete. This column shows your progress over time.

How Kanban Differs from a Simple To-Do List

To-Do Lists: - Linear, one-dimensional - Doesn't show work in progress - Hard to see the big picture

Kanban Boards: - Visual, spatial organization - Shows work-in-progress clearly - Provides workflow visibility - Encourages finishing before starting

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Your Dashboard

When you log into Tasking, you'll see your **Kanban board** as the main interface.

Dashboard Components

1. **Header**
2. Shows "Tasking" branding
3. Displays your username and role (Student)
4. Logout button
5. **Action Buttons** (above the board)
6. **Add Task**: Create a new personal task
7. **Groups** (if applicable): View your group assignments
8. **Upload Tasks**: Import multiple tasks from a CSV file (advanced)
9. **Kanban Board**
10. Four columns: Pending, In Progress, Blocked, Completed
11. Task cards in each column which can be dragged to order them
12. Drag-and-drop capability to move tasks between columns
13. **Task Cards**
14. Display task title
15. Show due date (if set)
16. Display task type badge (color-coded)
17. Click to view full details

Navigation Tips

- **Click on a task card** to view full details, edit, or delete
- **Drag tasks** between columns to update their status
- **Scroll within columns** if you have many tasks

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- **Use the search/filter** (if available) to find specific tasks

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Adding Tasks

You can add two types of tasks: 1. **Personal tasks** you create for yourself 2. **Tasks assigned by instructors** (you cannot create these, only receive them)

Creating a Personal Task

1. **Click the "Add Task" button** at the top of your dashboard
2. **Fill in the task form**:
3. **Title** (required): A short, descriptive name
    - Example: "Complete Lab 3 - Arrays"
4. **Description** (optional): Details about what needs to be done
    - Example: "Implement array sorting algorithms and complete all test cases"
5. **Due Date** (optional): When the task should be completed
    - Use the date picker or enter manually (YYYY-MM-DD format)
6. **Task Type** (optional): Select the category that best fits
    - See Task Categories Explained below
7. **Resource URL** (optional): Link to relevant materials
    - Example: GitHub repository, Google Doc, reading material link
8. **Click "Add Task"** to save
9. **Your task appears** in the "Pending" column

Quick Task Entry Tips

- **Keep titles short but descriptive**: "Study OOP Concepts" instead of "Study"
- **Add due dates** to stay accountable
- **Link resources** so you can quickly access materials
- **Choose the right task type** to organize your work visually

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Task Categories Explained

Tasking supports **nine task types** to help you categorize your work. Each type has a specific purpose and appears with a different colored badge for quick visual identification.

1. Group Programming Project

What it is: Collaborative coding projects where you work with other students

When to use: - Team-based programming assignments - Collaborative application development - Hackathon-style group projects

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Example: "Build a full-stack web app with Team Alpha"

Tips: Link to your group's GitHub repository in the Resource URL field

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2. Individual Programming Lab

What it is: Solo coding exercises and programming challenges

When to use: - Daily coding labs - Algorithm practice - Individual coding assignments - LeetCode-style challenges

Example: "Complete Lab 5: Linked Lists"

Tips: These are usually the most frequent tasks in your program

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3. Reading

What it is: Reading assignments, documentation, or technical articles

When to use: - Assigned textbook chapters - Technical documentation review - Blog posts or technical articles - API documentation

Example: "Read 'Effective Java' Chapter 3"

Tips: Add the reading material link to Resource URL for quick access

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4. Documentation

What it is: Writing documentation, README files, or technical writing

When to use: - Creating README files - Documenting your code - Writing technical specifications - Creating user guides

Example: "Write README for portfolio project"

Tips: Good documentation is as important as good code!

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5. Resume

What it is: Building, updating, or reviewing your professional resume

When to use: - Initial resume creation - Resume updates after learning new skills - Resume review sessions - Portfolio building

Example: "Update resume with new Java skills"

Tips: Keep your resume updated throughout the course

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6. ProDev (Professional Development)

What it is: Professional skills, networking, and career preparation activities

When to use: - LinkedIn profile building - Mock interviews - Networking events - Career coaching sessions - Communication skills workshops

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Example: "Complete LinkedIn profile optimization"

Tips: Professional development is just as important as technical skills

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7. Demo/Presentation

What it is: Preparing and delivering presentations or project demos

When to use: - Project demonstrations - Presentation preparation - Public speaking practice - Showcase events

Example: "Prepare final project demo presentation"

Tips: Practice makes perfect—rehearse your demos!

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8. Research, Analysis or Design

What it is: Research tasks, system design, or architectural planning

When to use: - Technology research - System architecture design - Database schema planning - UX/UI design work - Competitive analysis

Example: "Research microservices architecture patterns"

Tips: Good design happens before coding starts

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9. Organize

What it is: Planning, organizing, and meta-work about your work

When to use: - Weekly planning - Organizing your workspace - Setting up development environment - Creating study schedules

Example: "Plan sprint for week 6"

Tips: Spend time organizing to save time executing

Using Task Types Effectively

Color Coding: Each task type appears with a different colored badge on your Kanban board, making it easy to see the mix of work you have.

Filtering (if available): Some views let you filter by task type to focus on specific work.

Balance: Aim for a balanced mix—you need coding practice, reading, professional development, and more!

Organizing Your Work

Effective task management is a skill that will serve you beyond your time at Zip Code Wilmington. Here's how to use Tasking to stay organized.

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Daily Workflow

Morning Review (5 minutes): 1. Check your Pending column—what's due soon? 2. Review In Progress tasks—what can you finish today? 3. Check for new instructor-assigned tasks 4. Prioritize your top 2-3 tasks for the day

During the Day: 1. Move tasks to "In Progress" when you start them 2. Move tasks to "Blocked" if you get stuck and need help 3. Move tasks to "Completed" when finished (feels great!) 4. Add new tasks as they come up

Evening Review (5 minutes): 1. Update any task statuses 2. Add notes to tasks if needed 3. Plan for tomorrow

Weekly Planning

Sunday or Monday (15 minutes): 1. Review all upcoming due dates 2. Create tasks for the week's known work 3. Break large projects into smaller tasks 4. Estimate your capacity realistically

Prioritization Strategies

1. Due Date Priority: - Start with tasks due soonest - Leave buffer time for unexpected issues

2. Dependency Priority: - Tasks that block other work come first - Group projects often have dependencies

3. Impact Priority: - High-impact tasks (projects, assessments) before low-impact tasks

4. Energy Priority: - Do hard cognitive work (coding, design) when you're fresh - Do lighter work (reading, organizing) when you're tired

Managing Work in Progress

Limit your WIP (Work in Progress): - Try to keep no more than 2-3 tasks "In Progress" at once - Finish tasks before starting new ones - Context switching is expensive—focus pays off

Why this matters: - Multiple partially-done tasks = nothing done - Completed tasks = progress you can show - Focus = better quality work

Using the Blocked Column Effectively

When to mark tasks as Blocked: - Waiting for instructor feedback - Blocked by a group member's incomplete work - Missing access to required resources - Technical issues preventing progress - Need clarification on requirements

What to include: - Move the task to Blocked - Add a comment/note explaining what's blocking you - Notify your instructor if needed

Benefits: - Instructors can see where students need help - You can move on to other work - Clear visibility of bottlenecks

Breaking Down Large Tasks

Large assignments can be overwhelming. Break them into smaller tasks:

Example: Instead of one task: "Complete Final Project"

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Create multiple tasks: - "Design database schema for final project" - "Set up GitHub repo and project structure" - "Implement user authentication" - "Build REST API endpoints" - "Create frontend components" - "Write unit tests" - "Deploy to production"

Benefits: - Less overwhelming - Clear next steps - Visible progress - Easier to track time

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Working with Instructor-Assigned Tasks

Instructors can assign tasks to you in several ways. Understanding how these work helps you stay organized.

Types of Instructor Assignments

1. Individual Assignment: - Assigned directly to you - Appears in your Pending column - You're the only student with this task

2. Cohort Assignment: - Assigned to your entire cohort (e.g., all Java11.2 students) - Everyone in your cohort sees the same task - Common for lectures, readings, or assessments

3. Group Assignment: - Assigned to a specific group of students - All group members see the task - Use for team projects

Identifying Instructor-Assigned Tasks

Instructor-assigned tasks: - You cannot edit the title or description - You can update the status (move between columns) - You can add your own notes/comments - May have a "Created by: instructor1" indicator

Your Responsibilities

For instructor-assigned tasks, you can: - View task details - Update the status (Pending → In Progress → Completed) - Move to Blocked if you need help - Add personal notes or comments - View due dates and requirements

You cannot: - Delete instructor-assigned tasks - Change the title, description, or due date - Modify task type or resource URL

Managing Assigned Work

Priority: Instructor-assigned tasks are usually required coursework—prioritize them!

Communication: If an assigned task is unclear, mark it as Blocked and ask for clarification

Completion: Move assigned tasks to Completed when you've finished the work

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Instructor View Capabilities

It's important to understand what instructors can and cannot do with your board.

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What Instructors CAN Do

View Your Progress: - Instructors can see your Kanban board - They can see which tasks are Pending, In Progress, Blocked, or Completed - They can see when you moved tasks to different statuses - They can view your personal tasks

Why this is helpful: - Instructors can identify students who need help - They can see if you're falling behind - They can offer support proactively - They can track cohort-wide progress

What Instructors CANNOT Do

Modify Your Board: - Instructors **cannot** move your tasks between columns - They **cannot** edit your personal tasks - They **cannot** delete your tasks - They **cannot** change your task statuses

Why this matters: - Your board is yours to manage - You control your workflow - You decide when tasks move to Completed - **You own your progress**

Your Privacy

What's visible: - Your task titles and descriptions - Your task statuses and progress - Tasks you've created - How you're organizing your work

What's private: - Your personal notes (if implemented) - Your draft work - Your actual code (unless linked via Resource URL)

Working Together

This **view-only** approach means: - You maintain ownership of your learning - Instructors provide guidance, not micromanagement - You develop self-management skills - There's accountability without control

If you need help: Mark tasks as Blocked, and instructors will see you need support!

Tasking vs GitHub Projects

Both Tasking and GitHub Projects use Kanban boards, but they serve different purposes. Here's how they compare:

GitHub Projects

What it is: Project management tool integrated with GitHub repositories

Primary purpose: Managing software development within a repository

Best for: - Tracking issues and pull requests - Managing repository-specific work - Team collaboration on a single codebase - Open-source project management

Key features: - Linked to issues and PRs - Milestone tracking - Repository-specific - Public or private to repo - Great for code-centric workflows

Tasking

What it is: Personal task management system for students

Primary purpose: Managing all aspects of your learning journey

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Best for: - Organizing work across multiple projects - Tracking non-coding tasks (reading, professional development) - Managing instructor assignments - Personal productivity - Cohort-wide organization

Key features: - Multi-category task types - Instructor assignment capability - Cohort-based organization - Personal and assigned work in one place - Not tied to any specific repository

When to Use Each

Use GitHub Projects when: - Working on a specific repository - Managing issues and pull requests - Coordinating with team members on code - You need integration with GitHub features

Use Tasking when: - Managing your overall workload at Zip Code Wilmington - Tracking reading assignments - Managing professional development tasks - Viewing instructor-assigned work - Organizing tasks that don't live in a GitHub repo

Using Both Together

Many students use both!

GitHub Projects: For your individual projects and group repositories - Track bugs, features, and pull requests - Manage project-specific work

Tasking: For your overall organization at Zip Code Wilmington - See all your work in one place - Track assignments across projects - Manage non-coding tasks - Include a link to your GitHub Project board in Tasking's Resource URL field!

Example workflow: 1. Create a Tasking task: "Complete authentication feature for Team Project" 2. Add Resource URL linking to your GitHub Project board 3. Track detailed issues in GitHub Projects 4. Update Tasking status when the overall feature is done

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Tasking vs Trello

Trello is a popular general-purpose Kanban tool. Here's how it compares to Tasking:

Trello

What it is: General-purpose visual collaboration tool

Primary purpose: Flexible project management for any use case

Best for: - General project management - Team collaboration - Personal productivity - Any workflow you can imagine

Key features: - Highly customizable boards - Power-ups and integrations - Labels, checklists, attachments - Public and private boards - Works for any industry or purpose - Flexible column names and structures

Strengths: - Extremely flexible - Great integrations - Beautiful UI - Mobile apps - Free tier available

Limitations for students: - No built-in instructor assignment features - Requires manual setup for each cohort - No predefined task categories for work - You need to create structure from scratch

Tasking

What it is: Purpose-built task management for students

Primary purpose: Managing course work and instructor assignments

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Best for: - Zipcode-specific workflows - Receiving instructor assignments - Categorizing work types - Cohort-based organization

Key features: - Predefined task categories for course work - Instructor assignment capability - Cohort integration - Built specifically for student-instructor workflow - Designed for Zip Code Wilmington context

Strengths: - No setup needed—ready for course use - Instructor can assign tasks directly - Task types match course reality - Integrated with your cohort - View-only instructor access built in

Limitations compared to Trello: - Less flexible (by design) - Fewer integrations - More opinionated structure - Course-specific (not general-purpose)

Key Differences

Feature	Tasking	Trello
Purpose	Course student task management	General-purpose project management
Instructor Assignments	✅ Built-in	❌ Manual workaround needed
Task Categories	✅ Predefined for course work	⚠️ Manual labels
Customization	⚠️ Limited (structured)	✅ Highly flexible
Cohort Integration	✅ Built-in	❌ Manual setup
Learning Curve	✅ Quick (opinionated design)	⚠️ Requires setup
Mobile App	❌ Web only (currently)	✅ Native apps
Integrations	⚠️ Limited	✅ Extensive
Cost	✅ Free for students	⚠️ Free tier + paid plans

When to Use Each

Use Tasking when: - You're a Zip Code Wilmington student - You want instructor-assigned tasks - You want a pre-structured course workflow - You need to see all course work in one place

Use Trello when: - You want to plan personal projects - You need deep customization - You want mobile apps - You're organizing non-course life (personal tasks, hobbies, etc.) - You want extensive integrations

Use both: - Tasking for course work - Trello for personal life, side projects, or extracurricular activities

Why Tasking Exists

Tasking was built specifically because general tools like Trello don't have: - **Instructor assignment features**: No built-in way for instructors to assign work - **Course task types**: You'd need to create labels manually - **Student-instructor workflow**: No view-only instructor access - **Cohort organization**: No built-in multi-tenant structure

Tasking = Trello + course-specific features - unnecessary flexibility

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Best Practices & Tips

Productivity Tips

1. Start Each Day with Your Board - Make Tasking your browser homepage during course - Review your board first thing in the morning - Know your priorities before you start coding

2. Keep Tasks Small - Tasks should take hours, not days - If a task takes more than 4-6 hours, break it down - Small tasks = more frequent completion = more motivation

3. Use Due Dates Wisely - Add due dates to important tasks - Leave buffer time before hard deadlines - Use due dates to prioritize

4. Limit Work in Progress - Finish tasks before starting new ones - Multitasking is a myth - Focus = faster completion

5. Update Regularly - Update your board at least twice daily - Don't let it get stale - Accurate boards are useful boards

Organization Tips

1. Name Tasks Clearly - Use descriptive titles: "Complete Arrays Lab" not "Lab 3" - Include context: "Study for Week 6 Assessment" - Make it scannable

2. Use Task Types - Assign the right category to every task - Visual variety helps you see balance - Mix of task types = holistic learning

3. Link Resources - Always add Resource URLs when relevant - Link to GitHub repos, Google Docs, readings - Save time finding materials later

4. Add Descriptions - Use the description field for requirements - Note what "done" looks like - Include acceptance criteria

Study Tips

1. Balance Your Work - Don't just do coding tasks - Include reading, professional development, documentation - Well-rounded = better prepared

2. Use Blocked Status - Don't suffer in silence - Mark tasks as Blocked when you need help - Instructors can't help if they don't know

3. Celebrate Completions - Moving tasks to Completed feels good! - Track your progress - Reflect on what you've accomplished

4. Weekly Reviews - Every week, look at your Completed column - Recognize your progress - Adjust your approach for next week

Avoiding Common Mistakes

❌ **Don't**: Create one giant task per project ✅ **Do**: Break projects into multiple smaller tasks

❌ **Don't**: Ignore instructor-assigned tasks ✅ **Do**: Prioritize assigned work—it's required!

❌ **Don't**: Keep all tasks in Pending forever ✅ **Do**: Move tasks through the workflow actively

❌ **Don't**: Have 10+ tasks In Progress ✅ **Do**: Limit WIP to 2-3 tasks maximum

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❌ **Don't**: Forget to add due dates ✅ **Do**: Use due dates to stay accountable

❌ **Don't**: Work in isolation when blocked ✅ **Do**: Mark tasks as Blocked and ask for help

Time Management

Pomodoro Technique + Tasking: 1. Pick a task (move to In Progress) 2. Work for 25 minutes (focused) 3. Take a 5-minute break 4. Repeat 4 times, then take a longer break 5. When done, move to Completed

Time Boxing: - Allocate specific time blocks to tasks - Add estimates in task descriptions - Track how long tasks actually take - Improve your planning over time

Staying Motivated

1. Visualize Progress - Your Completed column is your trophy case - Watch it grow week by week - Celebrate small wins

2. Set Weekly Goals - "This week I'll complete 10 tasks" - "This week I'll finish the authentication module" - Goals + tracking = achievement

3. Share Your Board - Discuss your progress with peers - Learn from how others organize - Accountability through visibility

4. Reflect and Adapt - What worked this week? - What didn't? - Adjust your approach - Continuous improvement

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Getting Help

If You Have Questions

About Tasking: - Ask your instructor - Consult this manual - Check with fellow students

About Your Tasks: - Mark as Blocked if you're stuck - Ask in your cohort chat - Schedule time with your instructor

Support Resources

- **Tasking User Guide**: This document
- **Instructor Office Hours**: For task clarification
- **Cohort Slack/Discord**: Peer support
- **Zip Code Resources**: General course support

Conclusion

Tasking is your command center for navigating the course experience. By using it effectively, you'll:

✅ Stay organized across multiple projects and assignments ✅ Never miss important deadlines ✅ Communicate your progress clearly to instructors ✅ Develop professional task management skills ✅ Reduce stress by seeing the big picture ✅ Build habits that will serve you in your career

Remember: The best task management system is the one you actually use. Make Tasking part of your daily routine, and it will pay dividends throughout your course and beyond.

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Ready to get started? Log in to Tasking and start organizing your course journey today!

Questions? Ask your instructor or check the main documentation.

Good luck with your studies! 🚀

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